

Mathematical Stories

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Lecture Notes

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Introduction

Purpose and Philosophy

These notes are an invitation to look at mathematics in a different way. For many students, mathematics has long appeared as a collection of formulas, rules, and mnemonic patterns: one recognises the type of problem, chooses a remembered procedure, performs the required operations, and moves on. Such skills have their place, but they are not the heart of mathematics. Mathematics begins when we stop for a moment and ask what we are really looking at, what kind of object has appeared, what question is being asked, what is known, what is unknown, and why a proposed step is justified.

The purpose of this course is therefore not only to practise calculations. We will learn how to read mathematical expressions, formulate precise questions, distinguish an object from its notation, notice structure, and build simple but meaningful chains of reasoning. A solved problem is valuable not only because it produces an answer, but also because it can reveal a method of thought: how to begin, what to observe, which assumptions matter, what can be transformed, what remains unchanged, and how a conclusion follows from earlier facts.

We will try to study this language from the inside. A definition should not be treated as a sentence to memorise, but as a way of introducing a new kind of object. A theorem should not be treated as a decorative statement, but as an answer to a clear question under precise assumptions. An example should not be treated as a template to copy blindly, but as a small experiment in reasoning. Even a simple calculation can show something important if we ask why it works and what it tells us.

For this reason, some habits of thought will deliberately return in different places. The same question of what is fixed and what is variable appears when we study functions, vectors, equations, and transformations. The same need for precision appears when we define a line, compute a derivative, solve a system of equations, or interpret an integral. A mathematical question can often be seen algebraically, geometrically, and conceptually. This repetition is intentional: it helps the reader recognise patterns of reasoning rather than only patterns of exercises.

The number of answers produced is not, by itself, a measure of progress. What matters is the quality of the work. Did we understand the question? Did we identify the object correctly? Did we choose notation consciously? Did we know why each important step was valid? Did we interpret or verify the result? These questions are not an addition to mathematics; they are mathematics being done carefully.

Mathematics is useful in physics, engineering, computer science, data analysis, modelling, and many other fields, but its value is not only practical. It is also a way of seeing. It teaches precision, discipline, imagination, and the ability to move from simple observations to general conclusions. These notes are meant to show a piece of that beauty, strength, and richness. The goal is not merely to survive mathematical techniques, but to begin to appreciate mathematics as the art of asking good questions and giving well-reasoned answers.

How the Course Works

This book is part of a weekly learning process rather than a collection of material to be read only before an examination. Each of the twelve thematic chapters is designed to support one week of study. A chapter provides the mathematical structure for the lecture, a complete narrative to which the student can return, and a starting point for individual problem solving and classroom discussion.

In a fifteen-week semester, the twelve thematic weeks establish the main rhythm of the course. The remaining time can be used to introduce the method of work, connect topics, revise important ideas, and present more substantial solutions.

The Weekly Learning Cycle

A student should not leave a topic behind when the lecture ends. A typical week consists of the following connected stages:

1. **Attend the lecture.** The lecture introduces the topic, motivates the central questions, and demonstrates how the relevant mathematical objects and methods should be read.
2. **Return to the chapter.** Read the corresponding chapter carefully after the lecture. The PDF is not merely a summary of slides. It is an organised narrative containing definitions, explanations, examples, interpretations, and mathematical arguments that can be examined more than once.
3. **Ask questions and clarify the material.** Mark every place where a definition, transition, calculation, or conclusion is not yet clear. Use the text, your own examples, classroom discussion, and appropriate digital tools to resolve these questions.
4. **Solve the complete assigned problem set.** Move from following an explanation to constructing arguments independently. Work on every assigned problem and prepare a separate, self-contained note for each one.
5. **Prepare professional mathematical notes.** Use precise notation, explanatory sentences, justified transitions, and a clear conclusion. The note should show not only the answer, but also how it follows from the given information, definitions, and earlier results.
6. **Present and discuss your work.** During exercise classes, be prepared to explain a solution, answer questions about its steps, and describe what you learned while preparing it.

These stages form one continuous process. Each stage prepares the next, and the presentation and feedback lead back to further reading, revision, and improved work.

Exercise Classes: Presentation, Feedback, and Revision

Presenting mathematics is part of learning mathematics. It reveals whether an argument has genuinely been understood and whether the student can communicate it clearly. During a presentation, the student should be able to read the notation, explain the role of each important formula, justify the method, and respond to questions without relying on AI to speak on the student's behalf.

Feedback given during exercise classes is intended for the whole group, not only for the student whose work is currently being presented. Everyone should follow the argument and listen carefully to the discussion. By comparing different examples, students learn what a complete solution looks like, which explanations make an argument clear, which steps require justification, and which weaknesses require revision.

Students should not focus only on comments addressed directly to their own work. Listening to feedback on the work of others provides a broader set of examples and develops an operational understanding of the course standards: what makes mathematical work clear, justified, and complete, and what still needs improvement.

The feedback concerns the mathematical work and its results, not the personal worth of the student. What is examined is the quality of the note, the understanding demonstrated in the

argument, and the clarity of the presentation. Feedback should identify what already works and what should be changed in order to produce a stronger solution.

The first submitted version does not always have to be the final version. Students should learn to receive comments, reconsider their choices, correct errors, add missing explanations, and improve both the written note and its presentation. Revision is not evidence of failure. It is a normal part of serious intellectual work.

This process is important throughout university study and later in professional life. Students and professionals are given tasks, asked to solve problems, expected to present results, and required to respond to feedback and critical review. Learning to improve an initial solution is therefore not an additional classroom exercise. It is a fundamental habit of responsible academic and professional work.

Progress and Assessment

Progress is demonstrated by the quality and increasing independence of the student's work. By the end of a weekly cycle, the student should be able to identify the main mathematical objects, state the essential definitions, solve representative problems, justify the principal steps, verify or interpret the result, and communicate the argument clearly.

Assessment in the exercise component focuses primarily on how the student works throughout the semester. Evidence of serious engagement includes:

- regular preparation and completion of the assigned problem sets,
- documented attempts to solve problems rather than bare answers,
- active participation in presentations and classroom discussion,
- separate, self-contained notes for individual problems,
- careful revision of work after feedback,
- increasing clarity, independence, and mathematical precision.

A student is not defined by the quality of the first solution or presentation. Some students may initially find mathematical notation, formal writing, or public explanation difficult. A weak beginning does not prevent a very good final grade for the exercise component. A student who works conscientiously, responds to feedback, corrects earlier weaknesses, and demonstrates substantial development may finish the exercise component with a very good grade.

This approach does not lower the standard of mathematical work. It recognises that reaching the standard through sustained effort and revision is itself a meaningful achievement. The exercise-component grade reflects a process of learning, not merely a snapshot taken at the beginning of the semester.

Systematic work according to these guidelines provides the basis for earning a passing grade for the exercise component. The examination is assessed separately and tests the student's mathematical knowledge and ability to use it independently. Regular work does not replace the examination, but it develops the understanding and skills that substantially increase the likelihood of successfully completing the course.

How to Prepare Mathematical Notes

A mathematical note is not merely a place where an answer is recorded. Its purpose is to show how a problem is understood, how relevant information is selected, how a method is chosen, and how a conclusion follows from definitions, assumptions, and earlier results.

Mathematical expressions are compact. A single formula may contain several ideas at once: objects, operations, conditions, and logical relationships. Reading a formula therefore means more than pronouncing its symbols. A student should be able to explain what the objects represent, what operation is being performed, why the expression is meaningful, and what information the formula provides.

The same principle applies to writing. A sequence of formulas without explanatory sentences rarely communicates a complete mathematical argument. Formulas should be connected by words that explain their role. A good solution tells the reader why a calculation is being performed, which definition or theorem is being used, whether its assumptions are satisfied, and how the result answers the original question.

Make the Note Self-Contained

Prepare one separate, self-contained note for each assigned problem, including all of its subparts. Begin by writing the problem or a complete and faithful formulation of it. The reader should not need to search through another document to discover what is being solved. After several weeks, you should still be able to open the note and understand both the question and the solution.

Identify what is given and what must be found, proved, or explained. Introduce the relevant notation and determine what kinds of mathematical objects appear in the problem. Before calculating, ask what information is available and what would count as a satisfactory answer.

Make the Reasoning Visible

Present the principal idea or method before, or while, carrying out the calculation. Important transitions should be explained with complete sentences. For example:

- Because the determinant is non-zero, the matrix is invertible.
- We may therefore multiply both sides by the inverse matrix.
- By the definition of the derivative, we consider the following limit.
- Since the direction vector is non-zero, it determines a line.
- Substituting the result into the original equation verifies the solution.

Such sentences are not decoration around the mathematics. They are part of the mathematics because they show the logical relationship between successive formulas.

It is not necessary to describe every elementary arithmetic operation. The amount of explanation should be proportional to the problem. A simple exercise may require only a few sentences, while a more substantial problem may require a longer argument. The goal is not to make every note long. The goal is to make every essential step understandable and justified.

Write as briefly as possible, but as completely as necessary.

A Complete Solution

A complete note should make the following five stages visible:

1. **Understand the problem.** Record the problem, identify the given information, and state clearly what must be found, proved, or explained.
2. **Choose a method.** Select the definitions, theorems, or techniques that connect the available information with the goal.
3. **Construct the argument.** Carry out the necessary steps and connect formulas with sentences that explain why each important transition is valid.

4. **Verify the result.** Check calculations, assumptions, domain restrictions, or geometric meaning whenever appropriate.
5. **State the conclusion.** Answer the original question clearly and in its proper context.

A result without its context is not a complete solution. A bare final answer, an unexplained sequence of formulas, or a few unconnected calculations will be treated as incomplete work and should be revised.

Quality cannot be replaced by quantity, but quality does not remove the obligation to complete the assigned work. Students are expected to prepare separate, complete solutions for the entire assigned problem set. Producing many unexplained answers is insufficient, but preparing one polished solution while ignoring the remaining problems is also insufficient.

Working with AI

We are studying in an age in which AI tools are widely available. The free versions of these tools are sufficient for the kinds of support expected in this course: asking questions, clarifying notation, generating simpler examples, checking reasoning, identifying missing steps, and improving the organisation of mathematical writing. Access to expensive software is not required.

AI should be used as an individual learning assistant. It may help transform rough calculations into clear mathematical prose, but it does not replace the student's mathematical work. Receiving a well-written answer is not the same as understanding it. The student remains responsible for checking every definition, calculation, assumption, conclusion, and formula included in the submitted note.

Use AI with a focused context. Work on one problem at a time and prepare one complete note for that problem. Do not paste an entire problem set into a single conversation and request all answers at once. Handling many unrelated tasks together encourages brief, generic, and mathematically weak notes. Focused work makes it easier to question each step, identify missing justifications, and produce a solution that can be understood and presented.

The one-problem-at-a-time principle does not mean that only one problem from the set should be prepared. Students are expected to repeat this focused process for every problem in the complete assigned set.

A polished AI-generated note is insufficient if the student cannot read its formulas, explain its terminology, justify its transitions, or present the argument independently. When using AI, ask not only for a solution, but also questions that deepen understanding:

- What does this formula mean?
- What mathematical object does each symbol represent?
- Why is this step valid?
- Which definition or theorem is being used?
- Are the assumptions of the theorem satisfied?
- Is there a simpler way to explain this transition?
- How can the result be checked?
- What should I be able to explain during class?

Preparing notes in this way is part of learning mathematics. It develops the ability to read notation, recognise mathematical objects, organise information, construct arguments, and communicate ideas precisely. Repeating this process for the complete problem set builds the habits of systematic and conscientious work that should accompany the student throughout university study and later professional life.

Student GitHub Workspace

The current instructions, problem templates, and technical workflow for student work are maintained in the public repository [dchorazkiewicz/Math_Problems_Repo](#). Students should create a public fork of this repository and commit their notes to their own fork. The course repository is the common template; it is not the place where individual student solutions should be submitted.

The repository contains a short map of the working process:

- `README.md` explains the purpose and structure of the workspace and provides the weekly index;
- `SOURCE_MATERIAL.md` links the current lecture PDF and maps each week to the corresponding LaTeX problem source used by an AI assistant;
- `NOTE_GUIDELINES.md` defines the standard of a complete mathematical note;
- `AI_WORKFLOW.md` describes the one-problem-at-a-time workflow with AI, review, commits, presentation, feedback, and revision;
- `AGENTS.md` gives a connected AI assistant the operational rules for working safely in the student's fork;
- the `docs/` directory contains twelve weekly folders and one Markdown file for each problem.

The workspace uses Markdown for student notes, Git and GitHub for version history and public forks, MathJax for mathematical typesetting, MkDocs for the web presentation, and GitHub Actions for automatic validation and deployment. These instructions and templates may be updated independently of this PDF, so students should consult the repository for the current working procedure. The repository links back to this PDF and to its LaTeX sources. Students use the PDF as the readable course material containing the theory, definitions, examples, and problem sets. A connected AI assistant uses the current mapped LaTeX file as the exact machine-readable source of a selected problem statement.

Chapter 1

The Cartesian Plane

1.1 Constructing Cartesian Coordinates from Euclidean Geometry

We begin with a Euclidean plane, not with ordered pairs and not with a coordinate system that has already been drawn. Points, straight lines, right angles, perpendicularity, congruent segments, and the Pythagorean theorem belong to the geometry available before coordinates are introduced. Our task is to construct, step by step, the additional choices that turn this plane into a Cartesian coordinate plane.

Remark

Coordinates do not create Euclidean geometry. They arise after we choose and construct a particular system for assigning numerical labels to points of an already existing Euclidean plane.

1.1.1 The Plane Before Coordinates

At first there is only a Euclidean plane. There is no distinguished straight line, no origin, no horizontal or vertical direction, no positive direction, and no numerical scale.



a Euclidean plane with no chosen coordinates

Definition

For the construction below we use standard Euclidean operations and theorems:

- constructing the straight line through two distinct points;
- choosing a point on a constructed line;
- constructing a right angle, equivalently constructing the unique perpendicular to a line through a chosen point;
- transferring a segment length with a compass;
- bisecting a segment;
- using the continuity of the Euclidean line when passing from a dense family of constructed marks to all real positions;

- applying the Pythagorean theorem to a right triangle;
- later, constructing and comparing circles and arcs and applying the law of cosines in a Euclidean triangle.

A right angle is available from the beginning as a Euclidean construction. What is postponed is its numerical measurement in radians or degrees.

1.1.2 First Construction: A Straight Line

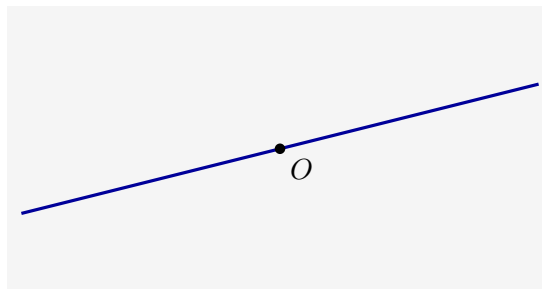
Choose two distinct points of the plane and construct the unique straight line through them. At this stage it is only a chosen Euclidean line. It is not yet an axis, because there is not yet a second line, an origin, a direction, or a scale.



the first constructed line

1.1.3 Second Construction: A Point on the Line

Choose an arbitrary point O on the constructed line. This point will later become the common zero of both coordinate axes, but it becomes an origin only after the rest of the coordinate structure has been constructed.

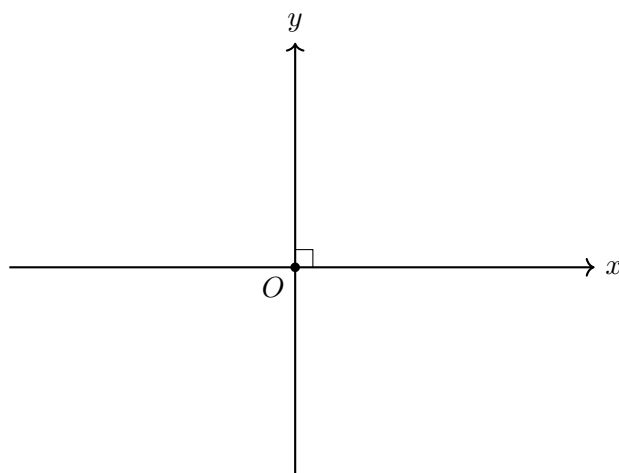


a point chosen on the first line

1.1.4 Third Construction: The Perpendicular Line

Through O , construct the unique line perpendicular to the first line. The two constructed lines now intersect at a right angle. Only now do we have the geometric framework from which two coordinate axes can be made.

We call the first line the x -axis, the perpendicular line the y -axis, and their intersection O the origin.

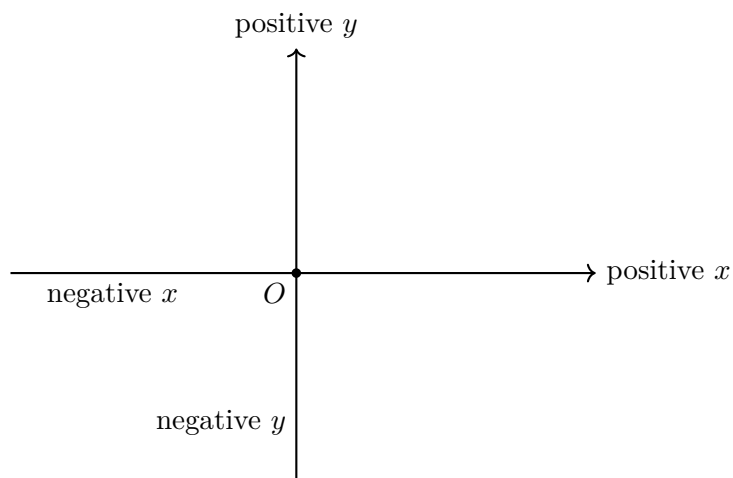


The axes are perpendicular because this was required in their geometric construction. No coordinate formula and no numerical angle measure has been used.

1.1.5 Choosing Positive and Negative Directions

Each axis is divided by O into two opposite rays. Choose one ray on the x -axis as positive and one ray on the y -axis as positive. The opposite rays are then called negative.

These choices are not forced by the Euclidean plane. Reversing one of them would produce a different coordinate system on the same geometric plane.

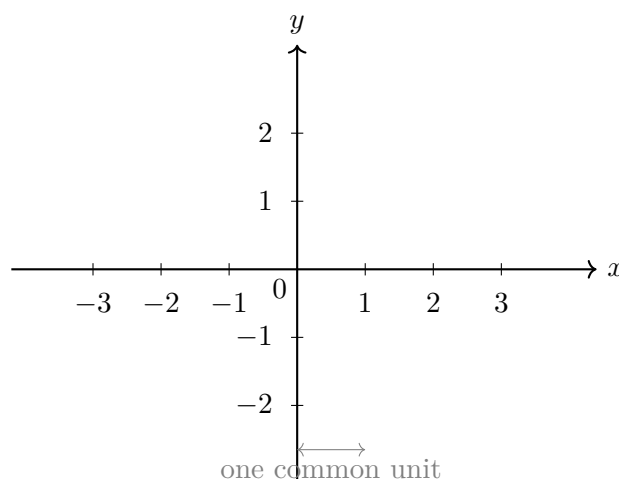


1.1.6 Constructing a Common Unit Length

Choose a positive segment length and call it one unit. Using a compass, transfer this same length from O repeatedly along both axes and in both directions. The first marks are labelled 1 and -1 ; repetition constructs the integer marks

$$\dots, -3, -2, -1, 0, 1, 2, 3, \dots$$

on each axis.



Remark

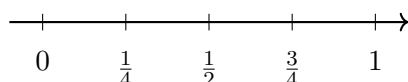
The same unit must be used on both axes. A segment labelled as one unit on the x -axis must be congruent to a segment labelled as one unit on the y -axis. This common scale is what later allows the Pythagorean theorem to produce the standard coordinate formula for Euclidean distance.

1.1.7 Refining the Scale by Bisection

The compass and straightedge construction does not stop at integer marks. Bisecting each unit segment constructs halves. Bisecting again constructs quarters, then eighths, and so on. Repeating this process on every integer interval and on both sides of the origin gives all dyadic marks

$$\frac{k}{2^n}, \quad k \in \mathbb{Z}, \quad n \in \mathbb{N}.$$

successive bisections of one unit



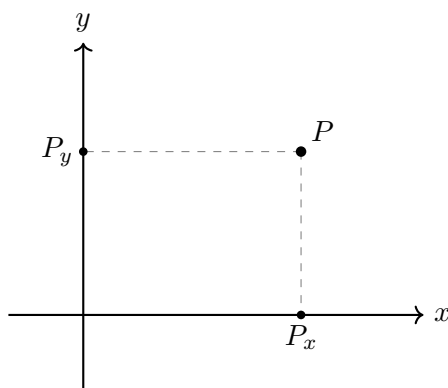
The dyadic marks are dense on the axis: every interval, however small, contains such marks. They therefore provide arbitrarily fine numerical approximations to positions on the line.

To pass from this dense constructed scale to a coordinate for every point of an axis, we use the usual Euclidean continuity assumption: the line has no gaps, and its positions can be put into one-to-one correspondence with the real numbers. After this step, every point of each axis has a unique signed real label, and every real number labels exactly one point of that axis.

1.1.8 Assigning Coordinates by Orthogonal Projection

Only after the axes, directions, common unit, integer marks, refined scale, and real labels have been constructed can an arbitrary point of the plane be given coordinates.

Let P be any point of the plane. Through P , construct the line perpendicular to the x -axis. It meets the x -axis at a unique point P_x . Through P , construct the line perpendicular to the y -axis. It meets the y -axis at a unique point P_y .



If the signed real labels of P_x and P_y are x and y , respectively, we assign to P the ordered pair

$$P \longleftrightarrow (x, y).$$

The construction is unambiguous because the perpendicular through a given point to a given line is unique. Conversely, given real numbers x and y , locate the corresponding points on the two axes and construct through them lines perpendicular to their respective axes. Those two lines meet in exactly one point of the plane.

Theorem

Once the two perpendicular axes, their positive directions, and a common unit are fixed, orthogonal projection gives a one-to-one correspondence

$$\text{points of the Euclidean plane} \longleftrightarrow \text{pairs } (x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2.$$

The ordered pair is the numerical address of a geometric point in the chosen coordinate system. It is not the point itself and it is not the source of the geometry.

1.1.9 The Coordinate Formula for Euclidean Distance

The Euclidean distance between two points is the length of the straight segment joining them. Coordinates now allow this geometric length to be calculated.

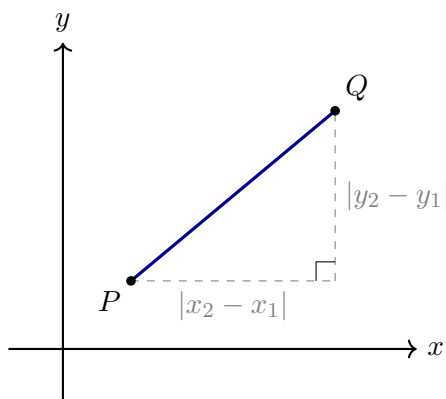
For points

$$P = (x_1, y_1), \quad Q = (x_2, y_2),$$

their projections show that the horizontal and vertical separations have lengths

$$|x_2 - x_1| \quad \text{and} \quad |y_2 - y_1|.$$

Together with the segment PQ , these two perpendicular segments form a right triangle. Here “right” refers to the Euclidean right angle already used in the construction; no numerical measure of that angle is required.



By the Pythagorean theorem,

$$d_E(P, Q)^2 = (x_2 - x_1)^2 + (y_2 - y_1)^2,$$

and therefore

$$d_E(P, Q) = \sqrt{(x_2 - x_1)^2 + (y_2 - y_1)^2}.$$

The formula does not create a new notion of distance. It is the numerical coordinate expression of the Euclidean segment length already present in the plane.

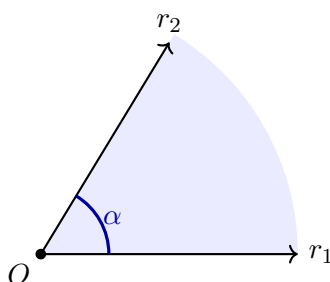
1.1.10 Angles and the Calculation of Their Measure

Right angles have already been used as Euclidean constructions: they are what make the axes perpendicular and what make the triangle in the distance formula a right triangle. We now make the general language of angles explicit and define how to assign numerical measures to angles.

Definition

Let r_1 and r_2 be two rays with the same initial point O . The rays, together with a choice of one of the two regions between them, determine an angle α with vertex O .

The angle is the chosen geometric region. It is neither the small arc drawn near the vertex nor a number. The arc is only a graphical mark indicating which region has been selected.



Why circles give a consistent measure

Draw a circle centred at O . The rays cut from the circle an arc corresponding to the chosen angle.

Theorem

For every Euclidean circle, the ratio of circumference C to diameter D is the same constant:

$$\frac{C}{D} = \pi.$$

This constant is called π . Since $D = 2r$, every circle of radius r has circumference

$$C = 2\pi r.$$

The constancy of C/D follows from similarity: enlarging a circle by a factor λ multiplies every length, including its diameter, circumference, and corresponding arc lengths, by λ .

If the same two rays meet two circles of radii r_1 and r_2 and cut arc lengths s_1 and s_2 , then

$$\frac{s_1}{s_2} = \frac{r_1}{r_2},$$

and therefore

$$\frac{s_1}{r_1} = \frac{s_2}{r_2}.$$

Thus the quotient s/r depends only on the angle, not on the chosen circle.

Definition

Let s be the length of the selected arc on a circle of radius r centred at the vertex. The radian measure of α is

$$m_{\text{rad}}(\alpha) = \frac{s}{r}.$$

For a full turn, $s = 2\pi r$, so

$$m_{\text{rad}}(\text{full turn}) = 2\pi.$$

A half-turn has radian measure π , and a quarter-turn has radian measure $\pi/2$.

Degrees are a second numerical scale. A full turn is assigned 360° , so

$$2\pi \text{ radians} = 360^\circ$$

and

$$m_{\text{deg}}(\alpha) = \frac{180^\circ}{\pi} m_{\text{rad}}(\alpha).$$

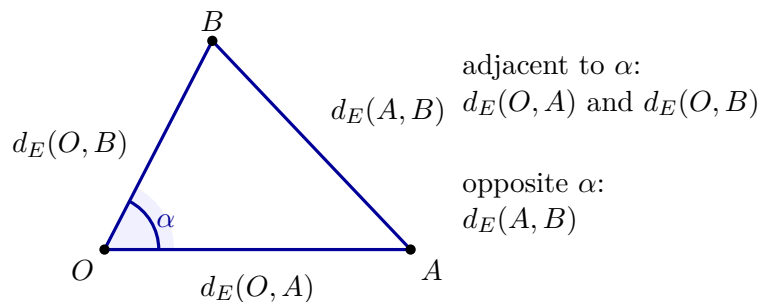
The law of cosines is inherited from Euclidean geometry

Directly measuring an arc is often difficult. We therefore use a theorem that belongs to the Euclidean geometry with which we started.

Choose points

$$A \in r_1 \setminus \{O\}, \quad B \in r_2 \setminus \{O\}.$$

The points form the Euclidean triangle OAB . Before writing the formula, we identify the angle and the three side lengths occurring in it.



The side AB is opposite the angle α , while OA and OB are adjacent to it. With these symbols fixed by the diagram, the classical law of cosines, proved geometrically without Cartesian coordinates, states that

$$d_E(A, B)^2 = d_E(O, A)^2 + d_E(O, B)^2 - 2d_E(O, A)d_E(O, B)\cos(m_{\text{rad}}(\alpha)).$$

Remark

The law of cosines is not created or justified by the coordinate system in this lecture. It is an earlier theorem of Euclidean geometry. Coordinates enter only when we calculate the three side lengths

$$d_E(O, A), \quad d_E(O, B), \quad d_E(A, B)$$

from the coordinates of O , A , and B .

Solving the Euclidean law of cosines for the angle measure gives

Theorem

$$m_{\text{rad}}(\alpha) = \arccos\left(\frac{d_E(O, A)^2 + d_E(O, B)^2 - d_E(A, B)^2}{2d_E(O, A)d_E(O, B)}\right).$$

The distance formula supplies the three numerical lengths needed in this expression.

The logical direction is therefore

Euclidean geometry and the law of cosines
 $\longrightarrow$ Cartesian coordinates
 $\longrightarrow$ numerical side lengths
 $\longrightarrow$ calculation of the angle measure.

Example

Let

$$O = (0, 0), \quad A = (1, 0), \quad B = (1, 1).$$

The coordinate distance formula gives

$$d_E(O, A) = 1, \quad d_E(O, B) = \sqrt{2}, \quad d_E(A, B) = 1.$$

The Euclidean law of cosines then gives

$$\cos(m_{\text{rad}}(\alpha)) = \frac{1^2 + (\sqrt{2})^2 - 1^2}{2 \cdot 1 \cdot \sqrt{2}} = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}.$$

Hence

$$m_{\text{rad}}(\alpha) = \frac{\pi}{4}, \quad m_{\text{deg}}(\alpha) = 45^\circ.$$

The angle is the geometric region determined by the rays OA and OB ; the numbers $\pi/4$ and 45° are two measures of that angle.

Definition

A *right angle* is the constructible angle formed by two perpendicular rays. Equivalently, two perpendicular lines meet so that the four angles around their intersection are congruent; each of these angles is called a right angle.

This name was already used earlier in the construction of the axes and in the Pythagorean triangle for the distance formula. The new information obtained now is numerical: if α is a right angle, then

$$m_{\text{rad}}(\alpha) = \frac{\pi}{2}, \quad m_{\text{deg}}(\alpha) = 90^\circ.$$

A right angle is not either of these numbers; it is a geometric angle having these measures in the two measurement systems.

Summary

The construction proceeds in the following order:

1. begin with a Euclidean plane containing no chosen coordinates;
2. construct one straight line;
3. choose a point O on that line;
4. construct through O the perpendicular line, and only then name the two lines as coordinate axes and O as their origin;
5. choose positive directions on both axes;
6. choose one common unit length and transfer it with a compass in both positive and negative directions to construct the integer marks;
7. repeatedly bisect intervals to construct the dense family of dyadic marks;
8. use Euclidean continuity to identify every axis position with a real number;
9. assign to every point its unique pair of orthogonal projections;
10. derive the coordinate distance formula from the resulting right triangle and the Pythagorean theorem;
11. only after this construction introduce the numerical measurement of general angles.

1.2 Another Way to Describe a Point: Polar Coordinates

The Cartesian description of a point uses two signed distances:

$$P = (x, y).$$

This is natural when horizontal and vertical directions are important. It is not, however, the only possible way to describe position in the plane. We may instead ask two different questions:

1. How far is the point from the origin?
2. In which direction do we move from the origin to reach it?

These questions lead to *polar coordinates*. For a point different from the origin, we use a pair

$$(r, \theta),$$

where

$$r > 0, \quad 0 \leq \theta < 2\pi.$$

The number r is the distance from the origin, and θ is the angle measured counterclockwise from the positive x -axis. The interval for the angle is half-open: it contains 0, but it does not contain 2π . This choice prevents the same direction from being written twice.

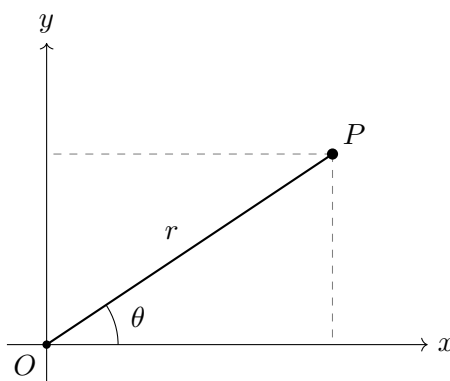
The origin is handled separately. We assign to it the single polar coordinate pair

$$O = (0, 0).$$

Thus the set of coordinate pairs used in this course is

$$\mathcal{P} = \{(0, 0)\} \cup ((0, \infty) \times [0, 2\pi)).$$

This should be read as follows: either we have the distinguished pair $(0, 0)$, which represents the origin, or we have a positive radius together with an angle from 0 up to, but not including, 2π .



The Cartesian and polar descriptions refer to the same point. The right triangle in the figure gives

$$x = r \cos \theta, \quad y = r \sin \theta.$$

Conversely, if the Cartesian coordinates are known, then

$$r = \sqrt{x^2 + y^2}.$$

For a point different from the origin, the angle is chosen uniquely from the interval $[0, 2\pi)$ so that its sine and cosine have the correct signs. For this reason, the formula $\theta = \arctan(y/x)$ must be used with care: by itself it does not distinguish all four quadrants.

Example

Consider the point whose polar coordinates are

$$(r, \theta) = \left(2, \frac{\pi}{3}\right).$$

Its Cartesian coordinates are

$$x = 2 \cos \frac{\pi}{3} = 1, \quad y = 2 \sin \frac{\pi}{3} = \sqrt{3}.$$

Thus the same point may be written as

$$P = (1, \sqrt{3})$$

in Cartesian coordinates and as

$$P = \left(2, \frac{\pi}{3}\right)$$

in polar coordinates.

Polar coordinates are especially convenient when distance from the origin is the main geometric feature. Let

$$C_R = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : x^2 + y^2 = R^2\}, \quad R > 0.$$

This is the set of all points in the Cartesian plane whose coordinates satisfy the condition

$$x^2 + y^2 = R^2.$$

Geometrically, C_R is the circle of radius R centred at the origin. After substituting

$$x = r \cos \theta, \quad y = r \sin \theta,$$

the Cartesian condition becomes

$$r^2 \cos^2 \theta + r^2 \sin^2 \theta = R^2.$$

Since $\cos^2 \theta + \sin^2 \theta = 1$, this reduces to

$$\boxed{r = R}.$$

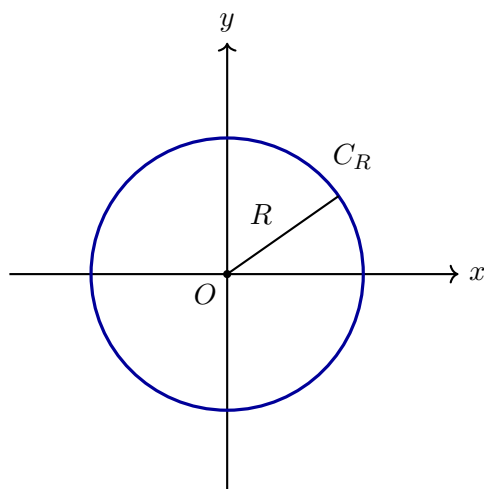
In polar coordinates, the same circle is therefore represented by the set

$$\{(R, \theta) : 0 \leq \theta < 2\pi\}.$$

The set C_R has not changed. The conditions

$$x^2 + y^2 = R^2 \quad \text{and} \quad r = R, \quad 0 \leq \theta < 2\pi,$$

describe the same geometric subset of the plane, but they use different coordinates. In Cartesian coordinates we express a relation between horizontal and vertical position. In polar coordinates we state directly that every point of the set has the same distance from the origin.



Remark

The restriction $0 \leq \theta < 2\pi$ is part of the definition used here. The angle 2π is not included, because it points in the same direction as 0. We do not identify or glue the endpoints of the interval. We simply choose one representative angle for each direction.

1.3 Lines in the Cartesian Plane

A line is one of the simplest geometric subsets of the plane. It can be drawn, described by a condition on coordinates, or defined explicitly as a subset of $\mathbb{R}^2$. We will keep these descriptions separate and explain how they are connected.

1.3.1 A Line as a Set of Points

Consider the condition

$$y = 2x + 1.$$

This is a relation between the coordinates x and y . The corresponding geometric object is the set

$$L = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : y = 2x + 1\}.$$

Definition

A non-vertical line in the Cartesian plane is a set of the form

$$L_{m,b} = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : y = mx + b\},$$

where $m, b \in \mathbb{R}$ are fixed.

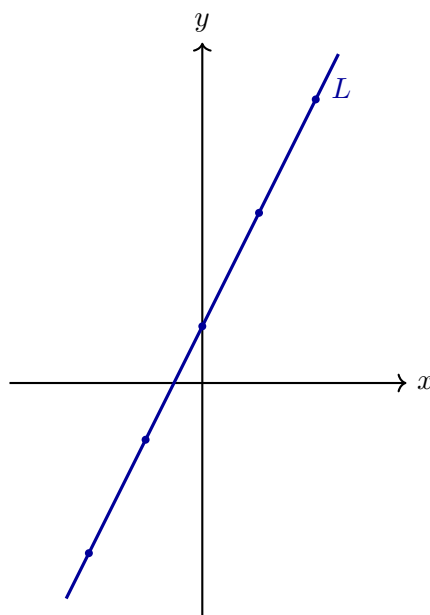
Every value of x determines exactly one value of y . For example, for $y = 2x + 1$ we obtain

x	-2	-1	0	1	2
y	-3	-1	1	3	5

and therefore all of the points

$$(-2, -3), \quad (-1, -1), \quad (0, 1), \quad (1, 3), \quad (2, 5)$$

belong to L .



Remark

A finite list of points only gives examples of elements of a line. The complete line is the entire set of points satisfying its defining condition.

1.3.2 Slope, Angle, and Vertical Change

Take two distinct points on a non-vertical line. Let their horizontal and vertical changes be

$$\Delta x = x_2 - x_1, \quad \Delta y = y_2 - y_1.$$

Because the line is not vertical, $\Delta x \neq 0$.

Definition

The *slope* of a non-vertical line is

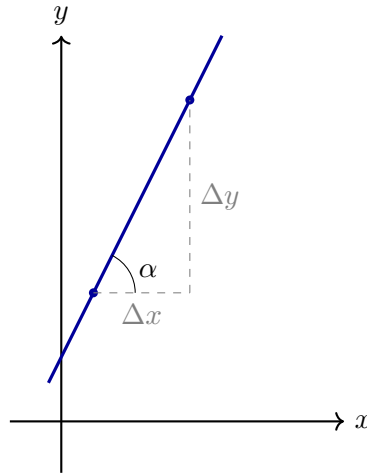
$$m = \frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x}.$$

It measures vertical change per unit of horizontal change.

For a line described by $y = mx + b$, replacing x by $x + \Delta x$ changes y by

$$\Delta y = m \Delta x.$$

Thus the coefficient m in the equation is exactly the geometric slope.



The line and the positive horizontal direction form an angle α . In the right triangle shown above, the tangent of α is defined as

$$\tan \alpha = \frac{\text{opposite side}}{\text{adjacent side}} = \frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x}.$$

Theorem

If α is an angle of inclination of a non-vertical line, then

$$m = \tan \alpha.$$

Thus slope is both a coordinate ratio and a description of direction.

The sign of m has a direct geometric meaning:

- $m > 0$: the line rises from left to right;
- $m < 0$: the line falls from left to right;
- $m = 0$: the line is horizontal.

1.3.3 The Constant Term and Axis Intersections

For the line

$$y = mx + b,$$

setting $x = 0$ gives $y = b$.

Theorem

The line

$$L_{m,b} = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : y = mx + b\}$$

meets the y -axis at

$$(0, b).$$

To find an intersection with the x -axis, set $y = 0$ and solve the resulting equation for x .

Example

For

$$L = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : y = -\frac{1}{2}x + 3\},$$

the y -axis intersection is $(0, 3)$. Setting $y = 0$ gives

$$0 = -\frac{1}{2}x + 3,$$

so $x = 6$. Hence the x -axis intersection is $(6, 0)$.

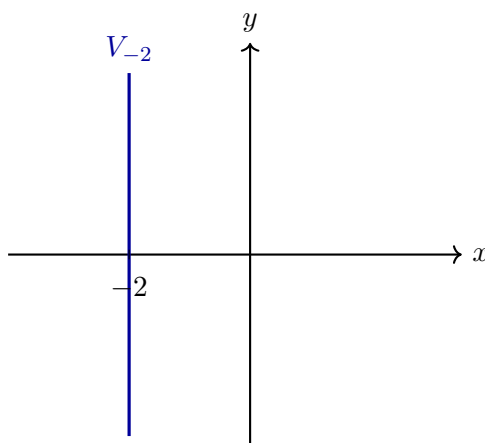
1.3.4 Vertical Lines

A vertical line cannot be written as $y = mx + b$, because one value of x is paired with every real value of y .

Definition

For a fixed $c \in \mathbb{R}$, the vertical line through $x = c$ is

$$V_c = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : x = c\}.$$



Remark

A vertical line has no real-valued slope. For two distinct points on it, $\Delta x = 0$, so the quotient $\Delta y / \Delta x$ is undefined.

1.3.5 The General Linear Equation

Definition

Let $a, b, c \in \mathbb{R}$, where a and b are not both zero. The set

$$L_{a,b,c} = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : ax + by = c\}$$

is a line in the Cartesian plane.

If $b \neq 0$, solving for y gives

$$y = -\frac{a}{b}x + \frac{c}{b}.$$

Therefore

$$\boxed{m = -\frac{a}{b}}, \quad \boxed{b_{\text{intercept}} = \frac{c}{b}}.$$

If $b = 0$, then $a \neq 0$ and the condition becomes

$$x = \frac{c}{a},$$

which describes a vertical line.

Example

For

$$L = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : 2x + 3y = 6\},$$

solving for y gives

$$y = -\frac{2}{3}x + 2.$$

Thus the slope is $-2/3$, the y -axis intersection is $(0, 2)$, and the x -axis intersection is $(3, 0)$.

1.3.6 The Line Through Two Points

Let

$$P = (x_1, y_1), \quad Q = (x_2, y_2)$$

be distinct points.

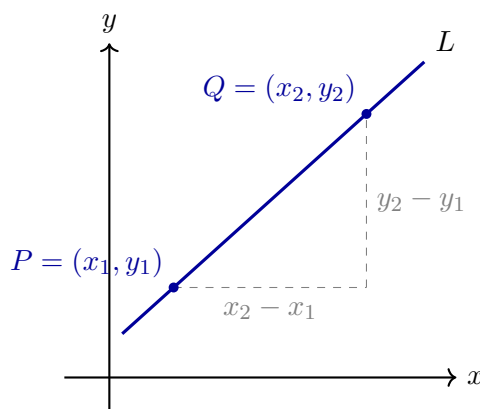
Theorem

If $x_1 \neq x_2$, the unique line through P and Q has slope

$$m = \frac{y_2 - y_1}{x_2 - x_1}$$

and can be defined by

$$L = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : y - y_1 = m(x - x_1)\}.$$



The second formula follows because every point (x, y) on the line must produce the same vertical-to-horizontal change ratio from P .

If $x_1 = x_2$, the two points determine the vertical line

$$L = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : x = x_1\}.$$

Example

The points $P = (1, 2)$ and $Q = (4, 8)$ give

$$m = \frac{8 - 2}{4 - 1} = 2.$$

Hence

$$y - 2 = 2(x - 1),$$

which simplifies to $y = 2x$. Therefore

$$L = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : y = 2x\}.$$

1.3.7 Parallel Lines

Definition

Two distinct lines L_1 and L_2 are *parallel* when they have no common point:

$$L_1 \neq L_2 \quad \text{and} \quad L_1 \cap L_2 = \emptyset.$$

Consider

$$L_1 = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : y = m_1x + b_1\}, \quad L_2 = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : y = m_2x + b_2\}.$$

A common point would have to satisfy

$$m_1x + b_1 = m_2x + b_2.$$

Equivalently,

$$(m_1 - m_2)x = b_2 - b_1.$$

If $m_1 \neq m_2$, this equation has exactly one solution for x , so the lines intersect. If $m_1 = m_2$, then either $b_1 = b_2$ and the lines are identical, or $b_1 \neq b_2$ and no common point exists.

Theorem

Two non-vertical lines are parallel precisely when

$$m_1 = m_2 \quad \text{and} \quad b_1 \neq b_2.$$

The equality of slopes is therefore a consequence of the geometric definition, not the definition itself.

Two distinct vertical lines are also parallel, because conditions $x = c_1$ and $x = c_2$ with $c_1 \neq c_2$ cannot hold at the same point.

1.3.8 Perpendicular Lines

Definition

Two intersecting lines are *perpendicular* when the angle formed at their intersection is a right angle:

$$\frac{\pi}{2}.$$

Let two non-vertical, non-horizontal lines have inclination angles α_1 and α_2 . They are perpendicular exactly when their directions differ by $\pi/2$. Thus we may write

$$\alpha_2 = \alpha_1 + \frac{\pi}{2}$$

up to reversing the direction along a line.

From the previously established relation $m = \tan \alpha$,

$$m_1 = \tan \alpha_1, \quad m_2 = \tan \alpha_2.$$

Using

$$\tan \left(\alpha + \frac{\pi}{2} \right) = -\frac{1}{\tan \alpha},$$

we obtain

$$m_2 = -\frac{1}{m_1}.$$

Theorem

For two non-vertical, non-horizontal lines,

$$L_1 \perp L_2 \iff m_1 m_2 = -1.$$

This criterion is derived from the geometric right-angle condition and the relation $m = \tan \alpha$.

A horizontal line and a vertical line form the remaining perpendicular case. The product formula is not applicable there because the vertical line has no real-valued slope.

Remark

Two lines may intersect without being perpendicular. Intersection only says that they have a common point. Perpendicularity additionally prescribes the angle at that point.

Summary

The central relations in this section are

$$L_{m,b} = \{(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2 : y = mx + b\},$$

$$m = \frac{\Delta y}{\Delta x} = \tan \alpha,$$

$$L_1 \parallel L_2 \iff m_1 = m_2 \text{ and } b_1 \neq b_2,$$

$$L_1 \perp L_2 \iff m_1 m_2 = -1 \quad (\text{non-vertical, non-horizontal case}).$$

Each algebraic criterion has been obtained from a geometric definition.

1.3.9 The Parametric Equation of a Line

The equations used so far describe a line by a condition that its coordinates must satisfy. A parametric equation describes the same line differently: we start from one point and move along a fixed direction.

Let

$$P_0 = (x_0, y_0)$$

be a point of the line, and let

$$(u, v) \neq (0, 0)$$

be a direction pair. Multiplying the direction pair by a real number t changes only the distance and orientation of the displacement, not its direction. Starting at P_0 therefore gives the points

$$(x, y) = (x_0, y_0) + t(u, v), \quad t \in \mathbb{R}.$$

Definition

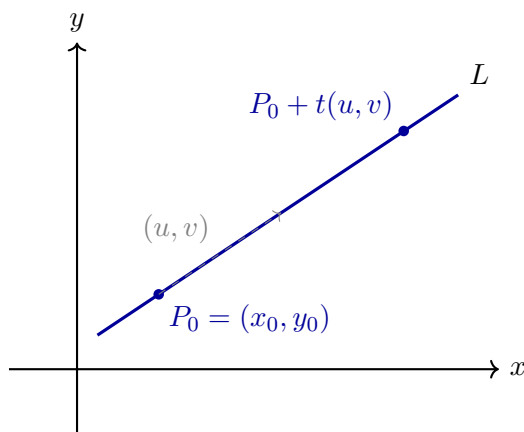
The line through $P_0 = (x_0, y_0)$ with direction pair $(u, v) \neq (0, 0)$ is parametrised by

$$L = \{(x_0 + tu, y_0 + tv) : t \in \mathbb{R}\}.$$

Equivalently, its coordinates satisfy

$$\begin{cases} x = x_0 + tu, \\ y = y_0 + tv, \end{cases} \quad t \in \mathbb{R}.$$

When $t = 0$, the parametrisation gives the initial point P_0 . Positive and negative values of t move from P_0 in the two opposite directions along the line. Since t ranges over all real numbers, every point of the line is obtained.



If $u \neq 0$, eliminating the parameter gives

$$t = \frac{x - x_0}{u}$$

and hence

$$y - y_0 = \frac{v}{u}(x - x_0).$$

Thus the slope is

$$m = \frac{v}{u}.$$

If $u = 0$, then $v \neq 0$ and the parametrisation becomes

$$x = x_0, \quad y = y_0 + tv,$$

which describes a vertical line. The parametric form therefore treats non-vertical and vertical lines in one uniform way.

For two distinct points

$$P = (x_1, y_1), \quad Q = (x_2, y_2),$$

the difference

$$Q - P = (x_2 - x_1, y_2 - y_1)$$

is a direction pair for their line. Consequently,

$$L = \{P + t(Q - P) : t \in \mathbb{R}\},$$

or in coordinates,

$$\begin{cases} x = x_1 + t(x_2 - x_1), \\ y = y_1 + t(y_2 - y_1), \end{cases} \quad t \in \mathbb{R}.$$

Example

The line through $P = (1, 2)$ with direction pair $(3, 6)$ has the parametrisation

$$\begin{cases} x = 1 + 3t, \\ y = 2 + 6t, \end{cases} \quad t \in \mathbb{R}.$$

Because $3 \neq 0$, we have

$$t = \frac{x - 1}{3}.$$

Substitution into the second equation gives

$$y = 2 + 6 \frac{x - 1}{3} = 2x.$$

Thus the parametric and Cartesian equations describe the same line.

Remark

A parametrisation of a line is not unique. Replacing (u, v) by any non-zero multiple $\lambda(u, v)$ changes the parameter but not the set of points on the line.

1.4 Second-Degree Equations and Conic Sections

Lines arise from equations in which the coordinates occur only to the first power. The next natural class consists of equations in which terms of total degree two are allowed.

Definition

A *second-degree equation* in the Cartesian plane has the form

$$Ax^2 + Bxy + Cy^2 + Dx + Ey + F = 0,$$

where $A, B, C, D, E, F \in \mathbb{R}$ and at least one of A, B , or C is nonzero. Its solution set is the collection of all points $(x, y) \in \mathbb{R}^2$ whose coordinates satisfy the equation.

The terms

$$Ax^2 + Bxy + Cy^2$$

form the quadratic part. The remaining terms affect the position and size of the curve, while the quadratic part largely determines its geometric type.

1.4.1 A First Classification

For the equation

$$Ax^2 + Bxy + Cy^2 + Dx + Ey + F = 0,$$

define

$$\Delta = B^2 - 4AC.$$

Theorem

For a non-degenerate real conic, the sign of Δ gives the following classification:

$\Delta < 0$	ellipse type, including circles,	
$\Delta = 0$		parabola type,
$\Delta > 0$		hyperbola type.

This classification is preserved by rotations and translations of the coordinate system. A rotation can remove the mixed term Bxy , while a translation can move the centre or vertex to a simpler position.

Remark

The sign of Δ identifies the conic type only after degenerate cases are separated. A second-degree equation may also describe a single point, no real points, one line, or two lines. These possibilities are discussed below.

1.4.2 Circle

A circle with centre (h, k) and radius $r > 0$ is described by

$$(x - h)^2 + (y - k)^2 = r^2.$$

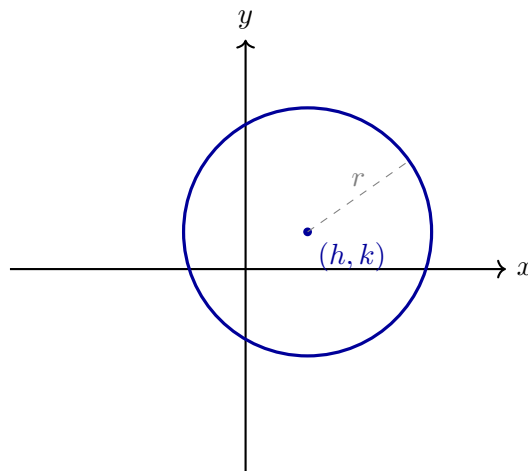
After expansion,

$$x^2 + y^2 - 2hx - 2ky + h^2 + k^2 - r^2 = 0.$$

Here $A = C = 1$ and $B = 0$, so

$$\Delta = 0^2 - 4 \cdot 1 \cdot 1 = -4 < 0.$$

A circle is therefore a special ellipse-type conic in which the coefficients of x^2 and y^2 are equal and there is no mixed term after a suitable rotation.



1.4.3 Ellipse

The standard ellipse centred at the origin has equation

$$\frac{x^2}{a^2} + \frac{y^2}{b^2} = 1, \quad a > 0, \quad b > 0.$$

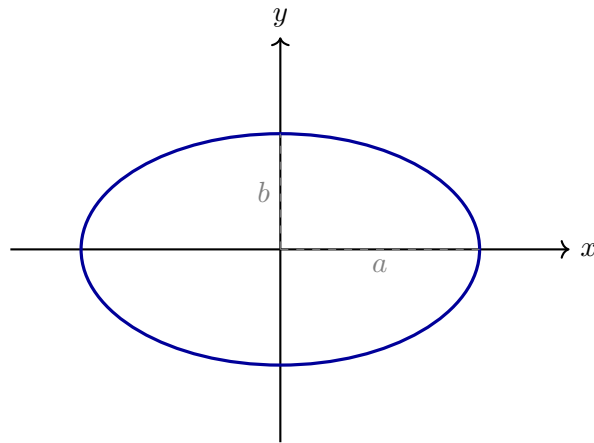
Equivalently,

$$b^2x^2 + a^2y^2 - a^2b^2 = 0.$$

Thus $A = b^2$, $B = 0$, and $C = a^2$, so

$$\Delta = -4a^2b^2 < 0.$$

The parameters a and b are the semi-axis lengths. When $a = b$, the ellipse becomes a circle.



1.4.4 Parabola

A standard vertical parabola has equation

$$y = ax^2, \quad a \neq 0,$$

or equivalently

$$ax^2 - y = 0.$$

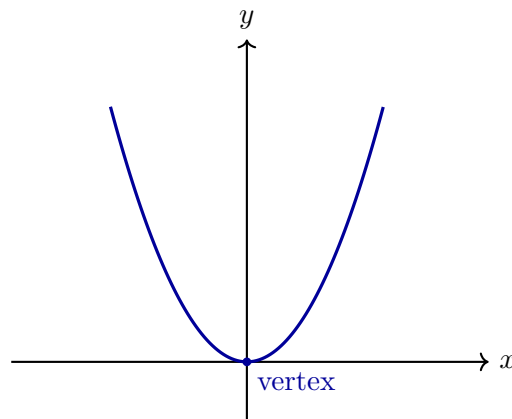
Here $A = a$, $B = 0$, and $C = 0$, hence

$$\Delta = 0.$$

The sign of a determines whether the parabola opens upward or downward. A translated form is

$$y - k = a(x - h)^2,$$

whose vertex is (h, k) .



1.4.5 Hyperbola

A standard hyperbola centred at the origin has equation

$$\frac{x^2}{a^2} - \frac{y^2}{b^2} = 1, \quad a > 0, \quad b > 0.$$

Equivalently,

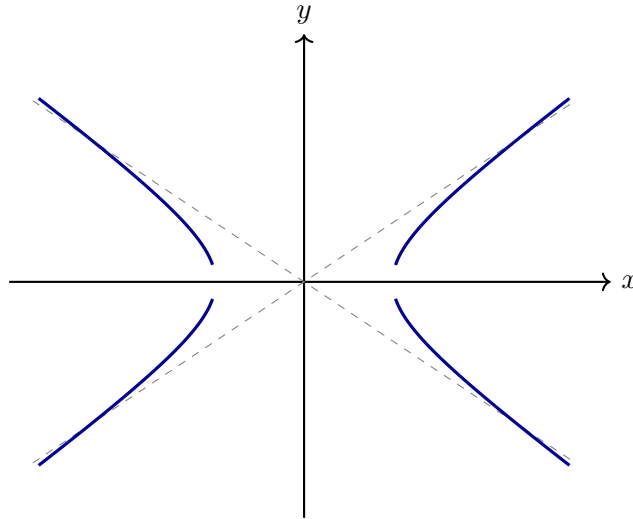
$$b^2x^2 - a^2y^2 - a^2b^2 = 0.$$

Here $A = b^2$, $B = 0$, and $C = -a^2$, so

$$\Delta = 4a^2b^2 > 0.$$

Its asymptotes are

$$y = \frac{b}{a}x, \quad y = -\frac{b}{a}x.$$



1.4.6 The Mixed Term and Rotation

The term Bxy indicates that the natural axes of the conic may be rotated relative to the chosen Cartesian axes. For example,

$$x^2 + 2xy + y^2 = 1$$

can be written as

$$(x + y)^2 = 1,$$

so it is not a non-degenerate ellipse: it describes the two parallel lines

$$x + y = 1, \quad x + y = -1.$$

For a genuine rotated conic, one introduces new coordinates (u, v) obtained by a rotation through an angle θ :

$$x = u \cos \theta - v \sin \theta, \quad y = u \sin \theta + v \cos \theta.$$

Choosing θ appropriately removes the uv term. When $A \neq C$, one may choose θ so that

$$\tan(2\theta) = \frac{B}{A - C}.$$

The resulting equation can then be classified in the new coordinates using the standard forms above.

1.4.7 Degenerate Second-Degree Equations

Not every second-degree equation describes a non-degenerate conic. Factorisation or completing squares may reveal a simpler set.

Example

The equation

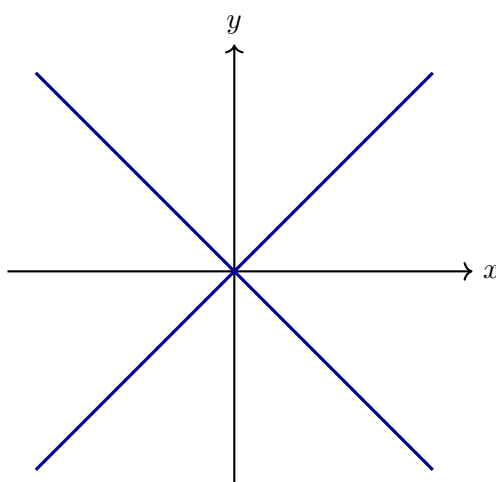
$$x^2 - y^2 = 0$$

factors as

$$(x - y)(x + y) = 0.$$

Its solution set is the union of two intersecting lines:

$$y = x \quad \text{or} \quad y = -x.$$



Other common degenerate cases include

$$x^2 + y^2 = 0,$$

which gives only the point $(0, 0)$,

$$x^2 + y^2 + 1 = 0,$$

which has no real solutions, and

$$x^2 = 0,$$

which describes the single line $x = 0$ counted algebraically twice.

Summary

Second-degree equations have the general form

$$Ax^2 + Bxy + Cy^2 + Dx + Ey + F = 0.$$

For non-degenerate real conics, the discriminant

$$\Delta = B^2 - 4AC$$

separates the three principal types:

$\Delta < 0$ gives ellipse type, $\Delta = 0$ gives parabola type, $\Delta > 0$ gives hyperbola type.

Translations and rotations reduce many equations to standard forms, while factorisation and completing squares expose degenerate cases.

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